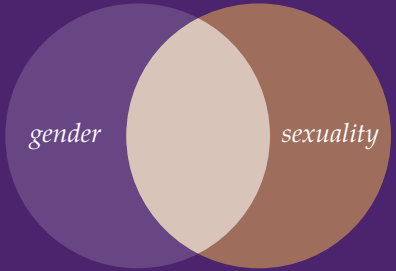
SOCIOLOGICAL METHODS · SHARING MY EXPERIENCE

Doing Sociology in the Field

Lessons from watching a gay bar and interviewing gay students



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What I wanted to know, and what came out

THE PUZZLE

Society marks gay men as "not man enough", a subordinated masculinity (Connell 1995). Yet inside gay spaces they seem to police femininity and pair off as opposites. How do gender and sexuality intersect?

A WATCHING

In a gay bar, opposites were matched: 13 of 22 pairs who left together were a 1 with a 0. Feminine-looking men were approached often but left with someone only once in 14.

B ASKING

Four gay students backed feminism in principle, felt uneasy about "radical" voices, and wanted to be allies while keeping the movements apart.

This talk is not about those results. It is about how I got the evidence: how I blended in, how I asked, what went wrong, what I changed, and what is still weak.

Two projects, four questions each

PROJECT A **Watching**

Participant observation in a Wuhan gay bar: 10 nights over two weeks (five a week), about 30 hours. I saw what men **do**.

PROJECT B **Asking**

Semi-structured interviews with four gay students at CUHK-Shenzhen. I heard what men **say**.

For each project I will answer the same four questions. The footer shows where we are.

1 How I did it → 2 What went wrong → 3 What I changed → 4 What is still weak

FINDINGS AT A GLANCE

Project A: what I found

1 MASCULINITY

A prize and a burden: sought as status in the bar's market, fled as duty at home and at work.

Finding 1 →

2 FEMININITY

Applauded on stage, discounted in person: feminine-looking men were approached 14 times and left with someone once.

Finding 2 →

3 MATCHING

Opposites are matched: 13 of 22 pairs who left together were a 1 with a 0; only 1 was 1–1 or 0–0.

Finding 3 →

More detail

1/0 and gender → | Natural or negotiated → | The order outside →

The model → | Approach log → | Coding sheet →

Ten nights, 90 logged approaches: a mechanism in one bar, not how common it is. Click a button to jump.

FINDINGS AT A GLANCE

Project B: what I found

1 SUPPORT

All four backed feminism in principle, and felt more supportive than straight men (as they perceive it).

Findings 1–2 →

2 UNEASE

Three of four disliked "radical" narratives that generalize about men; Thomas said gay men cannot step outside "men".

Findings 1–2 →

3 ALLIES, BUT APART

All saw the two struggles as linked, yet all wanted the movements kept separate.

Finding 3 →

More detail

Interview protocol →

Four students, one campus: how they reason, not how common it is. Click a button to jump.

Getting in: why a bar lets an outsider in fast

A bar is several settings at once

COMMERCIAL
drinks, tickets, staff: anyone who pays belongs

SOCIAL
strangers are expected to talk; approaching is the script

EROTIC
types and positions are displayed and negotiated openly

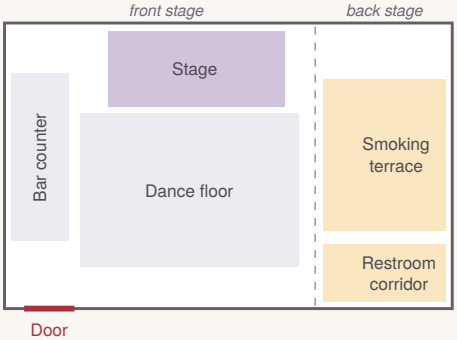
SPATIAL
door, floor, stage, terrace: each zone has its own rules

Why that lets a newcomer join within days

- **Low cost of entry:** a drink is a ticket; no membership or introduction
- **Newcomers are normal:** first-timers and friends of friends come every night
- **A ready-made script:** buy a drink, small talk, "what are you into?": I could join the very interactions I studied
- **A legible setting:** voices, bodies and labels are on display, so patterns show within a few nights
- **Plausible roles:** "curious student" or "friend of a friend": no pretence needed

Easy to enter is not easy to understand. Each layer has a different audience, so I needed a map, a role and a count. The next slides show how.

What I did: a map, a role, a routine, a count



Each zone has its own rules: the same man behaves differently at the door and on the terrace.

MAP Learn the zones first: each has its own rules

ROLE Observer for the first two nights, then joining in.

ROUTINE Jottings on my phone from the terrace or restroom; full notes within 24 hours

COUNT On 6 nights, a log of every approach I could see: who, which type, what happened

Going undercover: problems and fixes

	What happened	What I changed
"Who are you? 1 or 0?"	Asked within minutes; a vague answer felt evasive and the chat died	A short honest script, and I asked back (next slide)
Memory	Dark, loud room, no notes on the spot; by morning only the vivid scenes were left	Phone jottings; full notes within 24 hours; fixed windows and an approach log
Slipping into the role	Drinks, invitations, friendships: my notes began to sound like a regular's	A two-drink limit; a role check in my memo after each night
Consent in the dark	I cannot ask 120 people for permission	The manager's approval; told anyone beyond small talk; "don't write that"; no photos; no covert observation
Being watched back	Men performed for "the student": lower voices, tidier stories	Went five nights a week until I became furniture; compared nights with and without a regular beside me

Up close: the “1 or 0?” question

TRIED · WEEK 1

“Just looking around.”

Read as evasive. The man laughed and drifted off.

TRIED · WEEK 2

A joke: “Guess.”

Taken as flirting. The talk stopped being about the bar.

KEPT

“I can do both, but what about you?”

People laughed, then skipped in the most cases.

The awkward moment was data. The bar treats position like a business card: the question came up within ten minutes in 31 of the 40 opening conversations I could hear. Decide in advance how you will answer “who are you?”.

Interviews: how I did them

1. **Screen:** an online survey about sexual orientation identifies possible participants
2. **Sample:** four gay-identified students, chosen to vary by school and year
3. **Ask:** semi-structured interviews in Chinese, audio-recorded with consent; eight questions in three parts (Appendix A)
4. **Analyze:** verbatim transcripts organized into themes, read against the literature (in effect, thematic analysis; Braun & Clarke 2006)

Name	School	Year
Alex	Data Science	1
Ethan	Management & Economics	1
Thomas	Science & Engineering	2
Henry	Medicine	3

Pseudonyms; college names omitted.

Why interviews? The object was *perception*. A bar cannot show what someone thinks of feminism; only an account can.

Interviews: what went wrong

	What I noticed rereading my guide and transcripts	How I would fix it
Leading, double questions	"Do you support uniting the struggles? What could be the benefits or drawbacks?" invites a quick yes	One question at a time; open wording
Everyone agreed	"All four" on several points: fellow students, one campus, so politeness as much as evidence	Ask for examples; probe the "but"; add another interviewer
Who I could reach	Found through an orientation survey: self-selected, already "out". I said varied schools "control" other factors; four cases cannot	Say "maximum variation" (Patton 1990); about a dozen interviews before claiming patterns (Guest et al. 2006)
Lost in translation	Interviewed in Chinese, quoted in English	Keep the original beside the translation; a second reader checks

Fixing the questions: before and after

	As I asked it	What I would ask now
Q. E	*"As a homosexual man with a biological male gender, what is your attitude when encountering these different narratives or practices?"*	*"Think of the last feminist post or video you saw. What did you notice, and what did you do?"*
Q. H	*"Do you support uniting the struggle for gay men and other sexual minorities with the fight for gender equality? What could be the benefits or drawbacks of such an approach?"*	*"Have you ever seen the two causes come together, online or in person? What happened?"*
Q. D	*"Do you think your identity as a gay man has influenced your attitude toward feminism? If so, how specifically?"*	*"When did you first form an opinion about feminism? What was going on then?"*

Three habits I would now use. Pilot the guide with a friend. Ask for the last time it happened, not for an opinion. Treat silences and "but"s as data.

Watching versus asking: what each was good at

	Project A: watching	Project B: asking
Good at	what men do; who pairs with whom	reasons, self-descriptions, meanings
Bad at	why they do it; what a label means to the man who uses it	what they actually do; tidy, polite answers
What it cost me	30 hours, ethics worries, hours of note-writing	careful wording; a small, agreeable sample

Neither is truer. Talk shows how men want to be seen; watching shows what they do when the categories are under pressure (Jerolmack & Khan 2014). Watching gave me the puzzle; asking is how I would test the reasons.

Still weak: what I could not fix

PROJECT A

- **One bar, one city:** men who never go to bars are missing
- **One observer, one body:** who talked to me depended on my age, gender and student status
- **Watching without asking:** the matching is shown; the reasons are inferred
- **two weeks, one coder:** no trajectories; my coding was never checked

PROJECT B

- **Four students, one campus,** found through an orientation survey
- **No comparison group:** "more supportive than straight men" outran the evidence
- **"All" and "three of four"** imply prevalence
- **One coder,** and my reading of the literature shaped the themes

What I can claim, and what I cannot. A mechanism in one bar, and how four students reason. Not how common either is.

Take-home: six lessons for fieldwork

WHEN YOU WATCH

- ☐ Let the setting do the work of getting in, but plan your answer to “who are you?”
- ☐ Write before you interpret, and count what you can
- ☐ Treat awkward moments as data

WHEN YOU ASK

- ☐ Ask about episodes, one question at a time
- ☐ Pilot the guide, and be wary when everyone agrees
- ☐ Say what your case cannot show

Method is a chain of justified decisions. Keep a methods diary, so that you can defend every link.



Thank you

Questions and discussion



Backup

Findings, design details and instruments, in case of questions

Puzzle: four scenes from one night

1 DOOR · 22:50

A man says “Two” to the doorman in a low, flat voice. Ten steps later he shrieks a friend’s name, pitch up. At the street door, the low voice returns.

2 STAGE · 00:30

The drag host descends in a sequined gown; the room roars. The man beside me cheers, then mutters about someone at the bar: “Too *niang*. I can’t.”

3 BAR · 01:05

Two men meet at the counter. Within a minute: “So, 1 or 0?” They laugh, compare answers, and leave together ten minutes later. The louder, more muscular one had said “1”.

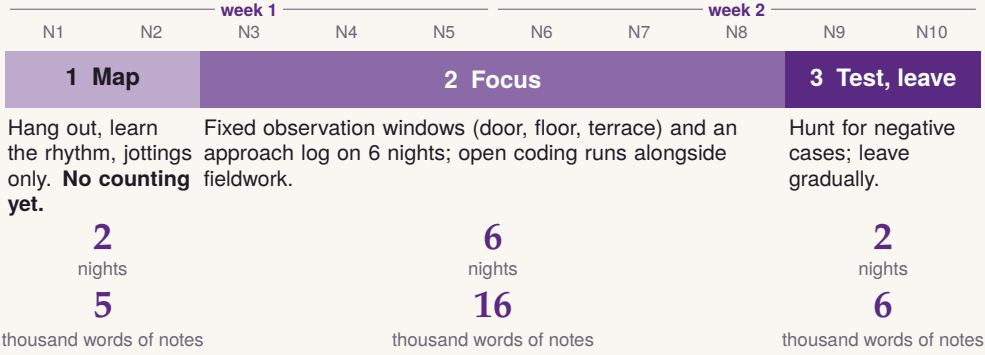
4 TERRACE · 01:20

Lin (34) lights a cigarette. “Mom asked again if I’m ‘seeing someone nice’. Coming here is the only time I’m not playing the good son.”

The puzzle. Men whom society marks as “not man enough” **police** femininity among themselves, pair off as complementary halves, and long to put masculinity down. Why?

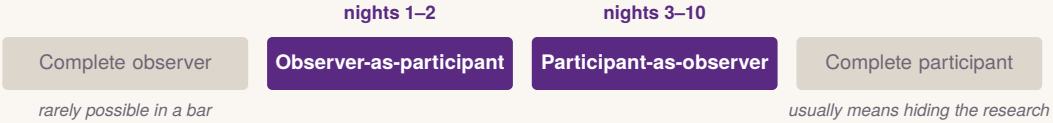
niang: slang for effeminate, usually pejorative. 1 and 0: the bar’s shorthand for the insertive and receptive sexual role. Scenes are condensed from fieldnotes; all names are pseudonyms.

Design: two weeks, three phases



Short on purpose. Two weeks, five nights a week. Depth came from going every night and from a setting that lets an outsider in quickly.

Design: roles, consent, and ethics



Field roles after Gold (1958).

Ethics as design decisions

- **Consent:** the manager approved the site; anyone I talked with beyond small talk knew I was a student researcher and could say “don’t write that”.
- **Anonymity:** bar renamed; no photos or recordings inside; jottings carry no names.
- **Data:** fieldnotes and the pseudonym key stored apart, encrypted.
- **Risk:** same-sex intimacy is legal but unrecognized in China; outing can cost family and job.

What I refused. Covert observation, and any attempt to trace people beyond the bar. Humphreys (1970) noted license plates to find men afterwards in *Tearoom Trade*: a standing warning.

Data: fieldnotes, or describing before interpreting

A three-step routine

1. **Jottings** on my phone from the terrace or restroom: keywords only
2. **Full notes within 24 hours:** scene, talk, sound, who stood where
3. **Weekly memo:** what surprised me? which other explanations fit?

About **27,000 words** of fieldnotes over 10 nights (about 30 hours).

FIELDNOTE · FRI 22:50

22:50 Man, mid-20s, black puffer jacket, says to doorman: "Two." Voice low, clipped.

22:53 On the stairs, to friend: "Baaaby!" Pitch up. Hand on friend's shoulder.

OC Register shifts at the threshold. A "masculine" voice as an entry ticket? Check other nights; ask in interviews.

Black = what happened. Red = my interpretation ("observer's comment"), kept visibly apart (Emerson, Fretz & Shaw 2011).

Data: an approach log of who matches whom

What I logged for each approach (6 nights, 90 approaches)

When, where	time and zone of the bar
Who	the bar's own type for each man (six types)
Position	the position each man declared (1, 0.5 or 0), if I heard it
Outcome	brush-off, short chat, long chat, or left together

The six types (as men in the bar named them)

Gym guy	muscled, masculine-looking
Bear	larger, hairy, masculine
Office guy	shirt, low voice, "straight-guy vibes"
Puppy	young, soft, boyish
Femme	flamboyant, feminine-looking
Uncle	over 40, settled

> **The types are the bar's words, not mine.** I coded a type from what men said about each other, and logged a declared position only when I heard it.

Scene terms: *zhinan gan* (straight-guy vibes), *xiao naigou* (puppy), *dashu* (uncle), *niang* (effeminate, pejorative).

← Project A findings

Finding 1: masculinity is both a prize and a burden

PURSUIT

- Praise for “straight-guy vibes”, or scorn for *niang*, overheard on 8 of 10 nights
- At the door, the voice drops to a “man” register on 5 of the 6 nights I watched

> *“If they hear a sissy voice, the conversation is over before it starts.”*
>
> Bo, 26, nurse · at the bar

FLIGHT

- Family and work demand a steady, provider “man”: marriage, an heir, a career
- On 5 of 10 nights a man stepped onto the terrace to take a call from home, and answered in his “man” voice

> *“I have to be a man twice: once at home, and once in here.”*
>
> Ming, 41, government employee · on the terrace

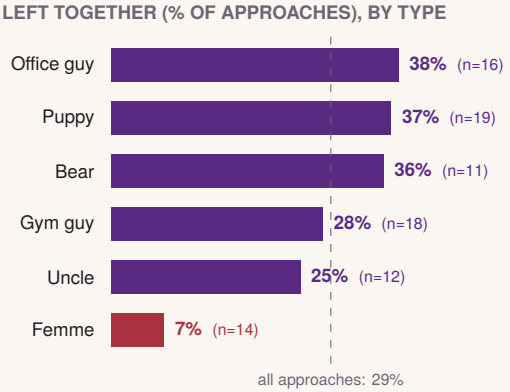
Same men, different audiences. Masculinity is *sought* as status in the bar’s market and *fled* as duty in the family and the workplace.

← Project A findings

Finding 2: applauded on stage, discounted in person

	On stage	On the floor
Framed as	performance	personhood
Logged	host performed on 4 of 10 nights	insulting *niang* on 8 of 10 nights, never during a show

> *"The queen is our star on Saturday. Nobody wants to date the queen."*
>
> Kai, 31, bar manager

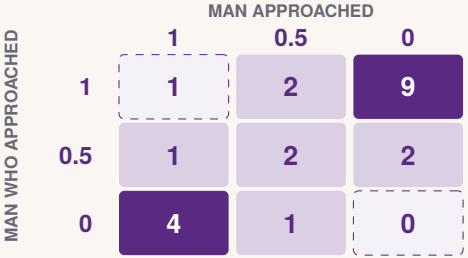


Front stage versus back stage (Goffman 1959). Femininity as spectacle is framed and safe; as a person, it is discounted. Men said "personality matters more than looks"; the log shows otherwise.

← Project A findings

Finding 3: opposites are matched

DECLARED POSITIONS OF THE TWO MEN WHO LEFT TOGETHER



n = 22 of the 26 pairs (both positions known). Dark: a 1 with a 0. Light: a 0.5 man involved. Dashed: same position.

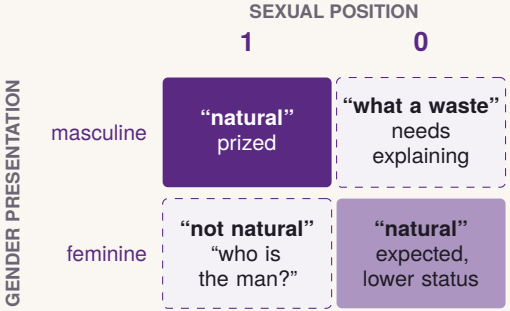
- 13 of 22 pairs (59%) were a 1 with a 0; only 1 (5%) was 1–1 or 0–0
- In 1–0 pairs the 1 made the approach in 9 of 13, and looked the more masculine man in 11
- "1 or 0?" came up within ten minutes in 31 of the 40 opening conversations I could hear

> *"One and one? That's just friends."*
>
> Hao, 29, fitness coach · to a man he had just met

Complementarity. The bar's matching logic borrows the heterosexual template of two complementary halves.

← Project A findings

Finding 4: 1/0 turns sexual position into gender



Solid: the “natural” pairings. Dashed: the 4 anomalies; onlookers commented on 3 of them.

> *“I say I’m a 1 first, before they guess.”*
>
> Bo, 26, nurse

> *“People hear ‘0’ and picture a girl. I go to the gym. I don’t want to be a girl.”*
>
> Yu, 22, student

Position works as a gender credential. Naming it repairs, or damages, a man’s standing *as a man*.

← Project A findings

Finding 5: “natural” on top, negotiated below

SAME MAN, SAME NIGHT

> *“I didn’t choose 1. It’s just who I am. You don’t learn that.”*
>
> Hao, 29 · 23:10, to a man he had just met

> *“With my ex I was more of a 0.5. I don’t say that in here.”*
>
> Hao, 29 · 01:40, to a friend on the terrace

WHAT I OBSERVED

- Position was described as inborn (“natural”, “you just know”) on 7 of 10 nights
- “0.5” worked as a hedge: a flexible man was in 8 of the 22 pairs, and named himself so mostly out of the crowd’s earshot
- Couples borrowed husband-and-wife talk and mocked it in the same breath

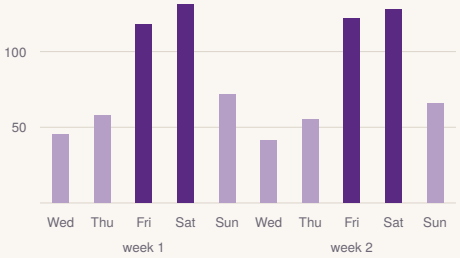
Naturalization is a social achievement. In a market that ranks men by position, a “natural” story makes a label look stable. The contradiction within one evening is data, not noise.

← Project A findings

Finding 6: the heterosexual order enters the bar

- **Family:** marriage pressure, the heir, and "cooperative marriage" (*xinghun*): two men I talked with were in one or arranging one
- **Work:** a steady, unmarked "man" at the office; "no drama"
- **Scripts:** husband-and-wife templates, "who is the man?"

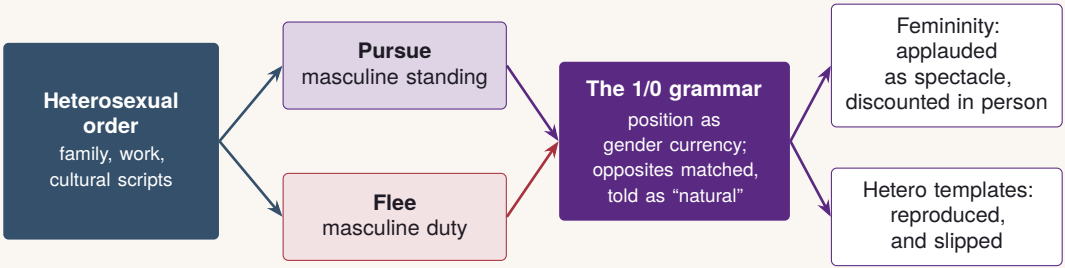
> *"On Sunday they leave by eleven. Tomorrow they have to be normal again."*
>
> Kai, 31, bar manager



Headcount at 23:30, by night. Weeknights are quiet: the working week sets the bar's rhythm.

← Project A findings

Synthesis: an intersection, not two parallel axes



Claim. Sexuality is used to repair gender standing, and gender presentation is used as a credential in the sexual market: **one currency, not two axes**.

← Project A findings

Findings 1 and 2: support, and some unease

FINDING 1 **Support; feeling more supportive**

> *"Heterosexual men, as a relatively privileged group, may not perceive the injustices experienced by women."*
>
> Henry

> *"The shared experience of marginalization enables homosexual men to empathize with women's struggles, making them more inclined to support feminism."*
>
> Alex

FINDING 2 **Unease with radical voices (3 of 4)**

> *"Such (radical) narratives could lead to the stigmatization of men, as they may subconsciously encourage women to generalize that all men exhibit certain behaviors."*
>
> Ethan

Thomas added, in the paper's paraphrase, that gay men cannot be excluded from the category of men. Henry was indifferent.

Reading it. The same men who see themselves as allies also place themselves *inside* "men": masculinity is a boundary they still live on.

← Project B findings

Finding 3: allies, but apart

YES TO SOLIDARITY

- All four saw the two struggles as positively linked
- Thomas: South Korea's feminist movement helped widen legal protection
- Alex and Ethan: employers hesitate over married women and over men who come out

NO TO MERGER

- Ethan: a forced union could dilute both movements
- Henry: feminism is old, while gay men are still invisible in some countries
- Thomas: each cause is already contested; combining them may raise resistance

> *"In contrast, discrimination against homosexual individuals stems from prejudice against an entire group. From this perspective, the connection between these two forms of inequality appears relatively weak."*
>
> Alex

A position between the poles: the literature framed the choice as combined or separate; participants said "allies, but apart".

← Project B findings

Appendix A: Project B interview protocol

Part 1. Knowledge and understanding of feminism

A. In your view, what do you think feminism is? If you were to summarize feminism in one sentence, what would you say?

B. Do you think gender equality has been achieved today? What is your perspective on the feminist movements advocating for women's rights?

Part 2. Support or opposition, and the reasons

C. Can you provide an example of what you consider to be a feminist narrative or practice? Do you support or oppose it? Why?

D. Do you think your identity as a gay man has influenced your attitude toward feminism? If so, how specifically?

E. Feminist narratives in online media vary, some more radical, others more moderate. As a homosexual man with a biological male gender, what is your attitude toward these different narratives? What might be the reasons?

Part 3. Their own struggle and the feminist movement

F. The core focus of feminism is undoubtedly on women, but in practice, do you think feminism is limited to the female demographic? Why or why not?

G. The struggle for the legalization and de-stigmatization of gay men still has a long way to go. As a community member, do you think it is connected to the feminist fight for gender equality? If so, how?

H. Do you support uniting the struggle for gay men and other sexual minorities with the fight for gender equality? What could be the benefits or drawbacks?

← Project B findings

Appendix B: Project A approach log, coding sheet

Field	Values	Notes
When, where	hour; door, bar counter, floor, stage, terrace, corridor	logged on 6 focused nights: 90 approaches
Who	gym guy, bear, office guy, puppy, femme, uncle	the bar's own labels, coded from what men said
Declared position	1, 0.5, 0, unknown	only if heard, or told to me later; both known in 22 of the 26 pairs who left together
Outcome	brush-off; short chat; long chat; left together	26 of 90 (29%) ended with leaving together
Notes	register shifts, onlooker comments, who initiated	free text, coded afterwards

← Project A findings

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